

OPERATION RHINO VIRUS

Of a month that was filled with germ warfare, combat outfits and starry starry skies

Can working on a story have side effects, besides the usual late nights and caffeine addiction? This month, one of our cover stories, 'Virusproof forever', had a strange effect on the team.

Things were running smooth while we were redesigning Digit: stories were being furiously edited, writers told to write again, illustrations improved further upon, design and graphics being coordinated like never before. But glitches happen with nary a warning. A real-world virus quietly sneaked into people's systems and soon you could hear sniffles and sneezes all over the place.

The first casualty was Karan. Now taking time off to rest and recover would have put the schedule for the redesign back by a few days. So our assistant editor who is rarely seen in anything other T-shirt and a pair of shorts, gave in to the demands of the occasion and came dressed in 'full pants' and a jumper for an entire week.

The next to go down was the writer Avina. But with very tight deadlines to take care of, she simply updated the usual writer's arsenal of notepad, pen and dictaphone with a trusty box of tissue papers to combat the changing war scene. And in between juggling with her sniffles, researching her stories, going out to



ILLUSTRATION: Mahesh Benkar

interview people and then writing her articles, she also found time to pack and shift house.

Soon the virus infiltrated the bastions of the copy desk. Anshul, our copy editor, was the first victim at the desk and was missing in action for a day. But with stories piling up at his desk, he was soon back on the job and right where the action was—making up for lost time by working extra long, fortified with several cups of hot tea.

Although the virus had taken its toll,

it was not done yet. The design team was one area where it had not tried to spread its tentacles as yet. And so it marched on—

Shiva, our senior designer, was the next victim. But he too continued to man his post, trying out different layout options between coughs and sneezes.

The joke going around the office was that the virus was following the path of the stories...from planning to writing, copyediting and finally the design. We're wondering if it will next infect the production team. We are also wondering if we can draw lessons from our cover story, 'Virusproof forever'. One other suggestion floating around is that the next time we do a 'dangerous' story, we test it first for possible side effects. 

Adventures in Star Gazing

A story on supercomputing? That's no big deal for our writers. But ask a technology writer to interview celebrities and the initial reaction is one of sheer bewilderment: "But I don't know any!" That's what happened when we decided to include a small item on the favourite sites of celebrities.

But our 'proud-to-be-geeky' writers, who can talk technology backwards to you if they want, were not so easily put down.

Soon everybody pitched in at digging out every contact who could possibly help them get in touch with a celebrity. Obviously, most of them were eager for a brush with their favourite stars.

Now pinning down the stars is no easy task because of their busy schedules and the only time you can get hold of them is late at night.

Our writer Avina took the help of Adarsh Kaul from our Events team, to call

up people in the entertainment industry and try and track down the elusive stars. Adarsh dug out his little black book and they made some 30 calls in a single evening. Then followed a late night vigil by the phone waiting for responses.

Some of our more enterprising colleagues went on to scouting out cousins, aunts and uncles—folks whom they didn't know existed till that moment. Just another adventure in the remaking of Digit.